

A Few Must-Have Tools for Windows Systems Administrators

This article presents some of the most desirable free and open source software programs that Windows systems administrators must have in their arsenal of tools.



Systems administrators play a crucial role in organisations as they are solely responsible for the configuration, security, support and maintenance of the company's computer hardware. Nowadays, organisations are modifying and expanding their tech infrastructure regularly and moving from basic Windows and Linux servers to high performance computing and high speed networking. Various other technologies like cloud computing, grid computing and many open source technologies are also being integrated. Though the core responsibilities and day-to-day activities of sys admins have not changed, employers' expectations from them have risen at a rapid pace. It is, therefore, important that sys admins understand how the tech market is changing and how new technologies are evolving rapidly. To do that, they have to continuously update their skillsets.

Many open source tools are available in the market, for various day to day system administration tasks, and it is very tough for any sys admin to be familiar with all of them. This

article focuses on different open source tools that can be used by sys admins in various administrative, monitoring, security and maintenance tasks within the organisation. The most important factors that determine the use of such tools are cost-effectiveness, stability and security.

So let's take a look at some open source tools that every Windows sys admin should be aware of.

Wireshark

Wireshark, formerly known as Ethereal, is a free and open source packet analyser. It is primarily used for network troubleshooting, analysis, and software and communications protocol development-cum-research. It is a cross-platform tool that uses the Qt Widget Toolkit to implement the user interface and *pcap* to capture packets. Its non-GUI version is called TShark.

Wireshark is bundled with the *libcap/Winpcap* driver, which lets the user select the network interface controllers